FROM THE SYNTHETIC ERA

The Grade Card

Keep it by the screen.

First, the question.

How do you know that to be true?

Then sort the door. Is this deduction, intuition, or potentially corrupted borrowed history?

If it's borrowed, grade it.

Chain.

Who saw it, and who passed it on?

Example: your birthday. Your mother, a nurse, a clerk. You can name every link.

Witnesses.

Independent, or one source copied?

Example: the Maurice Jarre quote. It ran in obituaries on three continents. One student wrote it. One witness, seen again.

Original.

Is there a trace to check it against?

Example: the Lenin photo. The edit got caught because an uncut print survived.

Fit.

Does it hold up against what's already well established?

Example: the smoke by the Pentagon. The fire department and the Pentagon's own protection agency said there was no explosion.

Then weigh it. Build on it. Lean on it lightly. Mention it, labeled. Or set it aside until more comes in.

Trust proportional to the grade you can still inspect

— from “The Black Box”

FROM THE SYNTHETIC ERA

The Clean Link Checklist

For families. For the people who will ask you, someday, what really happened.

Keep

- Keep the originals. The first file off the phone. The print. The negative. Save edits as copies, never over the original.
- Write down the dates. On the back of the print, in the file name, in the album.
- Write down who was there.

Label

- Label every edit. *Restored. Enhanced. Colorized. AI made this.*
- Say *I think* when you think. *I saw* only when you saw. *I heard* when you heard.
- Call a tribute a tribute, not a record.

Before you pass it on

- Ask where it came from. Can you name the first link?
- Ask where everyone else is. Real events leave many angles.
- Count witnesses, not views.
- If it's big, wait. The higher the stakes, the harder you grade, and the longer you wait.

When a familiar voice or face asks for something

- A call that sounds like family, asking for money or a password: hang up, and call back on a number you already know.
- Don't let *it looks real* close the case.

When you catch a mistake

- Say so. Correct the copy you passed on, even late.
- Hand it down cleaner than you got it.